In 2009 the RNDP was set up to seize the electoral opportunities emerging from the initial small opening in the 2010 elections within the authoritarian context of military rule but in a period of high civil society mobilization (de Mersan 2015). RNDP members had political and socio-cultural activist backgrounds in the Rakhine ethno-nationalist movement, and many older leaders were former members of the ALD from the 1990s. The RNDP fielded a total of 44 candidates in the 2010 elections, and it won 35 seats consisting of 7 Amyotha Hluttaw, 9 Pyithu Hluttaw, and 19 State and Region Hluttaw seats (Burma News International 2011). It became a prominent political player at the national level, partly because of the explosive communal violence in Rakhine State and the prominent role of its chairman, Dr Aye Maung, in key national political events, such as the top-level six-party talks in April 2015 (Htoo Thant and Pyae Thet Phyo 2015). Despite its marginal political position in the state government, the RNDP in Rakhine State led many major political successes on the religious-nationalist agenda, such as the white-card holder vote cancellation, promulgation of the religion and race protection laws, and the rejection of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation and campaign against international aid agencies for their alleged bias towards the Muslim community.

The ALD and RNDP were two parties with significant political capital themselves, but their merger was especially important for ethno-nationalists. Achieving unity of various Rakhine political forces was a key ethno-nationalist desire, which had been expressed more strongly among the armed organizations based in the border area. Although the armed movements dated back to Myanmar independence from Britain, there had been little or no armed activity in Rakhine State since the late 1970s. The lack of potency of the ethno-nationalist armed activities was attributed partly to the divisive nature of Rakhine political groups. Despite their low profile, there have been many attempts to unite these smaller groups. In 1997, four Rakhine armed groups formed as the National United Party of Arakan, only to disintegrate again within two or three years. The Arakan National Council was formed in 2004, which also disbanded within a few years. As a result of the divisive nature of Rakhine politics, the unity of key political entities had become an important aspiration among the ethno-nationalists. The merger of the ALD and RNDP addressed this aspiration of Rakhine ethno-nationalism.

The unity of the ANP faced internal and external challenges just before the 2015 election campaign. Internal conflicts are said to have occurred along